



SW. Africa

The Namib Desert

A dramatic coastal desert, where terrain ranges from bare bedrock to high, mobile dunes that meet the sea

Stretching from the Atlantic to a high, inland plateau, the narrow Namib Desert extends for about 810 miles (1,300 km) along the coast of southwest Africa. Considered one of the world's oldest deserts, it is bordered to the north by the Kaokoveld Desert, which stretches into Angola, and to the south by South Africa's Karoo. In most places, the narrow Namib measures less than 100 miles (160 km) wide. Despite this, it is often viewed as having three sections: the Atlantic-influenced coastal strip; the Outer Namib, which takes up what remains of the western half; and the Inner Namib, comprising the desert's eastern half. Commonly called the Skeleton Coast, the coastal Namib receives almost no rainfall and instead relies on regular sea fogs for moisture. From sea level, the terrain rises, reaching about 2,950 ft (900 m) by the time the desert meets the base of the Great Escarpment to the east. In the Inner Namib, average annual rainfall is only around 2 in (50 mm).

Living the dry life

Dryness is such a feature of the Namib that it is believed to have been in an arid state for at least 55 million years. This makes it all the more surprising to find that the desert is home to animals ranging from adders and geckos to zebras and elephants. Parts of the Namib are also rich in plant life, including the ground-hugging, ragged-leaved tree tumbo (*Welwitschia mirabilis*), which captures moisture from sea fog and can live for more than 1,000 years.



▷ SEA OF SAND

At the heart of the desert lies the Namib Sand Sea, spanning an area of 12,000 square miles (31,000 square km). It is composed of two dune systems—an ancient, semistable one topped by a younger, active layer.

▽ ADAPTED FEET

The web-footed gecko's feet enable it to walk easily on top of desert sand, as well as to bury itself beneath the sand to avoid the daytime heat.

In the **southern Namib**, some **dunes** are up to **20 miles (32 km) long** and **790 ft (240 m) high**

